



# The Sign Changed Nothing

An audit of dispute rates across a pub-trivia circuit's laminated "phones away" honour policy

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## The problem

Pub-trivia operators have adopted laminated "phones away" honour signs across whole circuits. Little is known about whether the printed reminder changes what a table actually does, or merely formalises an expectation the quizmaster already enforced by tone.

## Research questions

- Does disputed-answer frequency differ between signed and unsigned venues across a season?
- Does a venue's dispute rate shift after it adopts the sign mid-season?
- Does the circuit's own compliance survey track anything the dispute log doesn't already show?

## Study design

- n = 58 venues · one trivia circuit · 16-week season · weekly quizmaster dispute log
- Sign adoption rolled out venue-by-venue mid-season (staggered natural rollout, 3 Mar–16 Jun 2025)
- Quizmaster compliance survey (self-reported) compared independently against the dispute log; no threshold adjusted post hoc

## What we found

Disputed-answer rates hold flat across the rollout, with no detectable shift attributable to sign presence. The self-reported compliance survey moves independently of the dispute log it is meant to track.



Weekly disputed-answer rate per 100 rounds, signed vs unsigned venues, Round 1 (3 Mar 2025) to Round 16 (16 Jun 2025): season means 4.1 vs 4.3, no divergence at any week (n = 58 venues).

## Implications

The honour sign changes what a venue can point to, not what a table does. Dispute rates already sat near their historic floor before rollout, leaving little room for a printed reminder to move them. The compliance survey keeps finding something to report regardless. Next: test whether a reminder spoken aloud each round, not laminated, shifts anything the sign didn't.

## Selected references

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No patron or quizmaster identifiers retained beyond venue number; disputes logged by round only.

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“Nobody checks their phone less because a sign asked them to.”

Disputed-answer rate: 4.1 per 100 rounds signed, 4.3 unsigned (n = 58 venues, one season).